



Notion Note:

RETHINKING
UNIVERSITIES
RANKING
FRAMEWORK FOR
INDIA.



**Sva-Bharat
Movement**

Initiative by SvaNiti
Policy Research Center.

www.svabharat.in
www.svaniti.in

+91 90675 47325
notion@svaniti.in

Proposal Issued:
15.05.2026



RETHINKING UNIVERSITIES RANKING FRAMEWORK FOR INDIA.

Overview

India's higher education ecosystem is at a pivotal juncture. With over 1,000 universities and more than 40,000 colleges, India hosts one of the largest higher education systems in the world. Yet, when examined through the lens of global rankings and standardised metrics, most Indian universities appear to underperform—not because they lack merit, but because they are being evaluated through a framework never designed with India's context, aspirations, or potential in mind.

SvaNiti Policy Research Center, through its education policy initiative—the Sva-Bharat Movement—proposes a critical re-examination of how we measure what universities do, and more importantly, what they should do. This concept note lays out the intellectual and policy case for developing a new, India-centric framework of university metrics, grounded in first principles thinking.



India's universities have the potential to become among the most transformative institutions in the world not by imitating global ranking leaders, but by fulfilling their own distinctive purpose: developing whole human beings, building a capable and innovative professional class, and solving the real and urgent problems of Indian society.

THE GAPS WITH CURRENT METRICS



The current university ranking landscape is dominated by global systems like QS and THE, alongside India's NIRF, all of which primarily prioritize measurable metrics such as research citations, infrastructure, and placement statistics. While these frameworks provide a standardized evaluation, they often reflect a narrow Western bias that favors research hubs over holistic development. Consequently, institutions frequently optimize for these specific "proxies" rather than focusing on their deeper social contributions or the actual qualitative growth of their students.

The Research Gap in Indian Universities

India produces a significant volume of academic publications, yet the translation of university research into real-world impact remains critically underdeveloped. Much research in Indian universities remains confined to journals with limited applicability to policy, industry, or community challenges. Current metrics incentivise quantity over quality, citations over impact, and international visibility over local relevance.

This creates a structural disconnect: universities chase rankings while the societal problems that surround them—unemployment, poor public health, rural underdevelopment, educational inequity—remain inadequately addressed.

The Missing Dimensions of Human Development

Current metrics are largely silent on the most important question a university should answer: Did the student grow as a human being? Did they develop the confidence, curiosity, critical thinking, and ethical grounding to navigate a complex world? These are not soft or unmeasurable qualities. They are the core outputs of a genuinely excellent university education, and their absence from ranking frameworks represents a fundamental failure of imagination in education policy.

THE NEED FOR AN INDIA-SPECIFIC FRAMEWORK

FIRST PRINCIPLE- THREE PILLARS INSPIRATION



A university should not just produce graduates, it should shape individuals, build professionals, and create impact in society.

Personal Development

At its core, education is about the individual. This pillar focuses on whether students leave university more aware, capable, and grounded than when they entered. It goes beyond grades to examine how students think, how they learn independently, and how they respond to uncertainty and change. A strong university environment nurtures curiosity, builds emotional resilience, and helps students develop a clear sense of identity, values, and purpose. It also ensures exposure to diverse ideas and experiences that shape a well-rounded worldview.

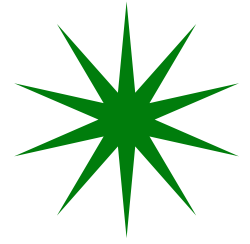
Professional Development

This pillar shifts the conversation from placements to preparedness. The question is not just whether a student gets a job, but whether they are equipped to grow, adapt, and lead over the course of their career. It looks at the depth and relevance of skills developed, including technical ability, communication, and leadership. It also evaluates how well universities foster innovation and entrepreneurship, and how closely they integrate with industry through curriculum design and real-world projects. Long-term alumni trajectories and the strength of mentorship systems become key indicators of success here.

Contribution to Society at Large

The true measure of a university lies in its relationship with society. This pillar assesses whether institutions are actively solving real-world problems and contributing to broader development. It considers the impact of research beyond academic publications, focusing on policy influence and community application. It also looks at outreach efforts, support for underserved communities, and contributions to local economic ecosystems. Equally important is how universities build partnerships with government, civil society, and industry, and whether their alumni continue to engage as responsible, socially conscious citizens.

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY: A FIRST PRINCIPLES APPROACH



The most promising ideas emerging from this open research process will be selected for pilot testing with partner universities. SvaNiti Policy Research Center will work with willing institutions to apply the three-pillar framework in a real context, collect baseline data, identify practical challenges, and refine the framework accordingly. Participating universities will be treated as co-creators of the framework—not subjects of evaluation.

Philosophy of the Research

The Sva-Bharat Movement is committed to a first principles approach. Rather than beginning with existing frameworks and asking how Indian universities perform against them, we begin with a more fundamental question: What is a university actually for?

Contributors to this research are invited to set aside existing assumptions and inherited definitions—and to reason from the ground up about the purpose of higher education in the Indian context. This asserts that India has the capacity and responsibility to build its own frameworks rather than borrowing from others.

To guide this endeavor, we draw inspiration from three key pillars that we have outlined.

Open Research Model

This research is intentionally designed as an open, participatory process. The Sva-Bharat Movement invites researchers, educators, students, policymakers, industry professionals, and community members to contribute as co-investigators. Contributions may take the form of:

- Original first principles research papers or essays on university purpose and metrics
 - Case studies of universities or educational initiatives exemplifying the three pillars
 - Proposed metrics, measurement tools, or evaluation frameworks
 - Critiques of existing ranking systems from an Indian perspective
 - Field research from specific institutional or regional contexts
- All contributions will be reviewed, synthesised, and integrated into an evolving framework document that will be made publicly available.